

A Theory of Us: Love Through Time and Space

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For my beloved wife

Our Engagement

Abstract

Love is often imagined as love at first sight, shaped by patterns, ideals, and expectations society teaches us to follow. You and I did not begin that way. We seemed different, and my feelings for you grew gradually through uncertainty, conflict, understanding, sacrifice, and change.

Like two particles meeting in a vast universe, we did not immediately move as one. We resisted, adjusted, and gradually found harmony. Through you, I learned to look beyond appearances and the inherited ideas of whom I was supposed to love. Belonging with you has made me feel more connected to myself, to the world, and to the meaning I find in life.

This paper is a proposal to you, my love. It asks whether love can endure disorder, pain, time, and transformation. Our story suggests that it can, not because love remains unchanged, but because we continue to choose one another as we change.

I love you through time and space, like a wave that never returns in exactly the same form, yet never truly disappears.

1 Introduction

In Plato's *Symposium*, Aristophanes tells a myth in which human beings were once whole and were later divided into halves, leaving each person with a longing to find the missing half from whom they had been separated. Yet love may not be about finding a perfect half, but about recognizing another imperfect half whose incompleteness reflects and complements our own [8].

We may have begun in similar ways without realizing how much we shared. Some of our weaknesses reflected one another, while others complemented what the other lacked. I see you in me, and myself in you: two people who are perfectly incomplete.

There is something almost ugly in this kind of love, but also something deeply honest. It is not built from glory, or perfection. It is built from flaws, contradic-

tions, wounds, and unfinished parts. Perhaps that is what makes it real. We do not love because we are complete; we love because, in our incompleteness, we continue to recognize and choose one another.

By learning to distinguish between you and me, I began to understand love and hate at the same time. They are not simply enemies, but opposing forces through which each becomes meaningful. We cannot fully understand happiness without sadness, nor can we truly understand love without knowing anger, pain, and even hatred.

This relationship resembles the principle of yin and yang: two opposite yet complementary forces that depend upon one another to form a whole [12]. It also recalls Tui and La, the Moon and Ocean Spirits in *Avatar: The Last Airbender*, whose names mean "Push" and "Pull". Their endless movement creates balance, and neither can fulfill its purpose without the other [3].

Perhaps we are similar. Our differences pull us apart and draw us together. Without one of us, something in the other remains unfinished, just as in Aristophanes' myth of the divided human being.

Perhaps love is not simply finding someone perfect. Perhaps it is finding the person whose incompleteness speaks most deeply to one's own.

2 Philosophical Concepts of Love

2.1 The Missing Half

Aristophanes' myth describes love as the desire for reunion [8]. Its truth is not scientific, but emotional. It explains why intimacy can feel like remembering something one never consciously knew.

This idea stands in sharp contrast to modern life. We are connected to an immense number of people, yet it often seems harder to truly find one another. Our choices are shaped by patterns, appearances, and social expectations, which can make love feel less like recognition and more like selection.

When I think about this, I cannot help feeling almost irritated by how lucky we were to find each other. What connects us seems to go beyond sight, sound, touch, or any ordinary sense. It feels instinctive, as though some part of us recognized the other before we fully understood why.

At times, this connection makes us feel invincible, as though we are “the last of a dying breed”, two people who found something genuine in a world where closeness has become increasingly rare. That feeling is captured in Fall Out Boy’s *The Last of the Real Ones* [4]. Finding you feels like discovering something I had almost stopped believing still existed.

2.2 Imperfection

The story of Adam and Eve begins with companionship, knowledge, disobedience, consequence, and exile. By eating the fruit from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, the first human couple chose knowledge despite God’s command, and with that choice came suffering, guilt, and mortality [10]. The first human relationship therefore does not unfold in a world protected from pain, but in one forever changed by imperfect decisions.

To me, this is one of the most profound beginnings in human literature. The moment humanity became capable of distinguishing good from evil was also the moment the first couple committed the first moral transgression. Love, then, does not begin in perfection. It begins alongside freedom, responsibility, and the possibility of failure.

Perhaps that is why genuine love is never the absence of imperfection. From the very beginning, human beings have loved while making mistakes, carrying guilt, and living with the consequences of their choices. We inherit not only their flaws, but also their courage to remain beside one another despite them.

Red Hot Chili Peppers’ *Wet Sand* reflects a similar acceptance of the person one loves [9]. To love someone is not merely to embrace what is bright, beautiful, or easy. It is also to accept the defects, darkness, and contradictions that belong to them. Love does not erase these imperfections; it gives them a place within something larger.

Like a mark left in wet sand, our existence together may be temporary and vulnerable to time. Yet the act of leaving that mark still matters. Even if the world changes around us, love allows two imperfect people to leave an impression upon one another that continues long after the moment itself has passed.

2.3 Entropy and Exchange

The second law of thermodynamics states that entropy tends to increase within an isolated system [2]. On the scale of the universe, this means that disorder generally increases over time, while structure can be preserved only through the continual expenditure of energy.

Relationships behave in much the same way. They require attention, apology, honesty, patience, and time. Love is not the absence of entropy. It is the decision to spend our energy creating and preserving order together.

The principle of Equivalent Exchange in *Fullmetal Alchemist* offers another useful metaphor: nothing meaningful can be gained without giving something in return [1]. We exchanged certainty for trust, comfort for growth, and some independence for companionship. We gave up parts of the lives we might have lived alone in order to build a longer journey together.

Yet this exchange did not erase our true selves. Instead, we offered parts of ourselves to one another and were transformed by what we received in return. We did not lose our freedom; we chose to turn it into commitment.

2.4 Change

Heraclitus is traditionally associated with the idea that one cannot step into the same river twice [5]. The river changes, and so does the person entering it.

You are not exactly the person I first knew, and I am not exactly the person who first met you. We are reshaped by every ordinary decision and every major turning point. The person I am today cannot fully represent who I once was or who I will become.

Love, therefore, cannot mean choosing one fixed version of another person forever. It means choosing that person again as she continues to change.

Loyalty is not a dull commitment to someone who remains the same. It is the willingness to remain beside someone through transformation. Like a river or a wave, love never returns in exactly the same form. It moves, reshapes itself, and changes with time, yet it does not have to disappear.

Twenty One Pilots explores a similar form of devotion in *Formidable*. The line “I’m afraid of you now, more than I was at first” captures the vulnerability of loving someone more deeply as they become more fully known [11]. Love, in this sense, involves continually rediscovering another person despite uncertainty. Such commitment is not loyalty to an unchanging image, but loyalty to the shared journey of becoming.

3 My Philosophy of Love

Love has never appeared perfect, even in the oldest stories told by our ancestors. Across myths, philosophies, modern stories, and the natural world, we encounter different visions of it: Adam and Eve’s first experience of imperfection, Aristophanes’ search for the missing half, the sacrifices demanded by Equivalent Exchange, and the endless movement of rivers and waves. Together, these ideas have taught me that love is not a single glorious moment. It is a process of finding, failing, giving, changing, and choosing again.

Time may be the most frightening force of all because nothing living can escape it. We are born, we change, and one day we die. Even our accomplishments may eventually be forgotten. Love cannot stop time, but it can resist the emptiness time seems to create. It allows our brief lives to affect another person, leaving care, memory, and meaning behind us.

Nena captures this hope beautifully: "Gib mir die Hand, ich bau’ dir ein Schloss aus Sand" ("Give me your hand, I’ll build you a castle out of sand"), followed by the refrain "Irgendwie, irgendwo, irgendwann" ("Somehow, somewhere, someday") [7]. A castle built from sand is fragile. It is destined to be washed away by wind and water, just as our lives are eventually worn away by time. Yet the beauty of the castle has never depended on its permanence.

Perhaps love is exactly this. It is choosing to build something together despite knowing it will always be vulnerable. When time erodes what we have built, we return to the shore, take each other’s hand again, and build another castle. Lifetime after lifetime, somehow, somewhere, someday.

I know how fortunate I am to be able to write these words to you and trust that you will receive them fully rather than dismiss me as foolish. I love you for your care, your thoughtfulness, and even your silliness. I love not only your brilliant little mind, but also your quiet and unassuming heart, which beats with compassion for people, plants, animals, and for me.

I feel as though I have loved you through more than one lifetime. In my mind, I sometimes test our future like a Monte Carlo simulation, a method that explores uncertainty by running many possible scenarios and observing the range of outcomes they produce [6]. I imagine countless versions of our future, including everything that might go wrong, because I am frightened by how much there is to lose.

At unexpected moments, these possibilities replay without warning. In one imagined future, I feel the deepest sadness; in another, the highest rapture. Love has taught me to experience both at once: the joy of having found you and the fear that comes from

knowing how precious you are.

I do not live only for one perfect moment. I live for the accumulation of moments we create together. I carry you through my brightest days and love you from within my darkest ones. Anything precious brings with it the possibility of loss, but I would rather accept that fear than live a life in which I had never found you.

4 Conclusion: The Vision of Us

To my wife, the person I love most: what matters is not simply how far we have come, but that, through every sorrow and every joy, we have continued to choose one another.

I want to share all the days still ahead of us, including those when the light disappears, when the sky seems to fall, and when the universe can no longer carry its own weight. I want to remain beside you until even the idea of love has vanished from this vast and isolated universe, until nothing remains to name what we have been to each other.

If this paper has reached any conclusion, it is this: love is not a final answer but a future we choose to create, day after day. The vision it leaves behind is simple: to keep choosing you, to keep growing with you, and to keep building a life together for as long as time allows. If the universe grants us only one lifetime, I will spend it loving you. If it grants us more than one, I will find you again, en esta vida y en todas las que sigan.

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